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"All that from two symbols?!": an *Adolescence* roundtable

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ABSTRACT

Adolescence (2025) is a hit television show that has sparked widespread debate in both the press and in government houses. In this collaboratively written response, we consider how the show might index relatively new social phenomena – that is, involuntary celibate (incel) culture, social isolation, anxiety about young people's engagement with social mediascapes – but also reproduce older social fears, such as threats to hegemonic institutions and the 'power' of media. In particular, we discuss the multiple ways that Stephen Graham *et al*.'s production at both the aesthetic and representational levels, grapples with structures, such as patriarchy, class and state institutional power (e.g. the prison, the school, the psychiatric discourse) through an attention to how 'symbols' are articulated through the programme, but also how *Adolescence* sparked more popular 'hot takes', hand wringing and celebration. We conclude that the show is compelling because it reproduces and problematizes through the immediacy of the one-take style the well-worn themes of vulnerable youth and family in peril.

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Introduction

Towards the end of Episode 2 of hit Netflix drama series *Adolescence* (Graham et al. 2025), Detective Luke Bascombe (Ashley Walters) is given a crash course in contemporary youth communications by his teenage son, Adam (Amari Bacchus). Bascombe is casting around for a motive after the murder of an adolescent woman, Katie (Emilia Holliday), by a male classmate, Jamie (Owen Cooper). He lands on 'online bullying' as the propulsion for Jamie's crime. Nonetheless, the detective remains at a loss for how such bullying *works* within the ubiquitous space of teen social media. Adam, embarrassed by his father's ignorance fills in the gaps. He becomes the knowledgeable digital 'native' teaching his father. After running through the vernacular meanings of red and blue pills and the bomb emoji, Adam hisses at Bascombe that Katie's comments on her killer's Instagram page designates Jamie as 'an *incel*'. Bascombe, perplexed, asks Adam 'you got all that from two symbols?'. Adam nods.

In the collaboratively written responses to *Adolescence* we offer here, we move between the position of Adam and Bascombe to consider how a series like *Adolescence*

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might index something relatively new – i.e. involuntary celibate (incel) culture; anxiety about young people's engagement with social mediascapes – but also reproduce older concerns and tensions. In particular, we riff off the multiple ways Graham *et al*.'s production grapples with existing structures such as patriarchy, class and state institutional power (the prison, the school, the psychiatric discourse) through an attention to how 'symbols' are articulated with social media through the programme, but also how the reception of *Adolescence* sparked popular 'hot takes', hand wringing and celebration. We ask: what work does this programme *do* in the contemporary conjuncture?

The responses below draw on a roundtable discussion we held at our University soon after the programme was released. *Adolescence* – celebrated for its episode-length single-takes (Goldbart 2025) – is not singular.

Adolescence is a four-part mini-series released on Netflix in March 2025. It tells the story of a brutal murder of a young woman, committed by an ostensibly 'normal' young man. The series unpacks the myriad contemporary circumstances and influences that led to such a violent act: social media; cyberbullying; misogynistic online content creators, as well as the role of ingrained structures, such as patriarchy, class, the institution of education and the family. Within 2 weeks of its debut, *Adolescence* became the first streaming series to lead UK television ratings and ignited a global discussion about online misogyny and its effects on young, impressionable, particularly male, social media users. By the end of the month, co-creator Jack Thorne had been invited to a roundtable hosted by UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer to address the issues highlighted in the show; Netflix had opened free access to *Adolescence* for all secondary schools across the United Kingdom; and media outlets in the United Kingdom, USA, Australia and New Zealand were publishing a flood of think pieces and opinion articles on digital misogyny, the crisis of masculinity and the risks of largely unregulated social media environments.

To return to Bascombe and Adam and their discussion of emoji. While Adam proposes a definitive reading of Katie's comments on Adam's social media as proof of both Katie's understanding of Jamie as simply *an incel* and that Jamie, therefore (following Katie's labelling) *is* an incel we – and Bascombe – are not so quick to 'close the case' as simply 'Andrew Tate shite' (to quote Bascombe's offsider DI Misha Frank [Faye Marsay]). As Bascombe and his son continue their (now-heated) discussion, we learn the problem of simple readings or interpretations of 'symbols'. In earnest, Bascombe asks if online bullying and incels 'affect you, son?'. Instead of answering, Adam notes replies: 'don't call me son – you call *other people* son'. The communication swerves, and we have the question of familial relationships – of fathers and sons – come to the fore. More important than *media effects* – is the operation of the word 'son'. For Adam, 'other people' are his father's sons: criminal people, or suspect people. But at the same time Adam is motivated by alleviating what he sees as his father 'blunder[ing] about', asking his classmates questions about the murder. Rather than providing his father with simple information (the 'real' meaning of the emoji) to solve the tricky question of Jamie's motive – Adam is more concerned that his father has lost face in his *lack of understanding* of contemporary media communication. Adam says to Bascombe, 'I just thought you needed to know [about the meaning of the emoji] – . . . it was *embarrassing* watching you blunder about'.

Miscommunications move through any straightforward reading of social relations and situations. The last scene in the same episode consolidates the imperative of more-than-

singular forms of communication and interpretation. Bascombe offers Adam a lift home from school and they go through the motions of a 'normal' father–son relation: 'what lessons did you have today, then?' asks Bascombe. Adam replies that he had French. Bascombe attempts banter: '*Français*? You speak French then?' Adam replies flatly '-*Je m'appelle … ça va bien … moi*'. Bascombe, chuckling, tells his son 'that's *enough;* you're destroying the language!'. They move into more familiar territory: grabbing a takeaway. But here too there's confusion. Adam says 'the Chinese on Chapel Hill' is the best spot for that British staple of chips. Bascombe asks 'now, why would we go to a Chinese for chips Adam?'. Adam answers simply: their salt and pepper chips are better than anywhere else. Misinterpretations occur; languages are 'destroyed' in *Adolescence*. Relations (fathers and sons; students and teachers) and places (France, Northern England, China) are mixed up.

Such misses and mix-ups are what makes *Adolescence* compelling media. Here, we move with our own voices to add to the conversation. We have chosen to delineate our own responses separately, but we hope that the reader will move, and *think*, with us in considering *Adolescence* as more-than-singular.

A universe explodes: Adolescence and the patriarchal system

Rosemary Overell

On first viewing of Episode 1 of *Adolescence*, I was struck by the violent intersection of the state apparatus of the police with the cultural formation of the family. This intersection and collaboration between the state and the family as instruments of ideology is something Brett will take up. It is gripping.

But what struck me re-watching this opening scene for the present discussion was … the wallpaper! Jamie has a universe on his wall, and his doona cover. This banal set-piece I think is significant. In the final scene of the series too, Dad, Eddie, collapses onto Jamie's bed, the wallpaper universe forming a backdrop which, we now see is *torn*. Further, the wallpaper does not quite line up. Such a tear is typical of a child's careless-ness with home décor, the misaligned paper likely the fault of a rushed DIY job. But I propose this is also a way in which we can think about how masculinity in *Adolescence* operates. There's a rip in this universe of men – of fathers and sons, of authority figures and those who comply with them. In this riff, I draw on Lacanian approaches to signification (1964 [1973/1998]) and the sexed subject (1970 [2010]). That is, I consider how a web – a system, a network – of signifiers constitutes the subject as man or woman.

So, here, I am attentive to such formal detail, not for the sake of connoisseurship or cataloguing an art-form, but for thinking through what such signifiers (wallpapers; universes; families) might tell us about the culture from which they arise. A universe of signifiers, and of meaning, exists, but we need to know what to do how to put them to work. Possibilities are out there in space. Link them together, and you have a solar *system*: planets, orbits, named after scientists spying through colossal telescopes.

Elsewhere in *Adolescence*, psychologist Briony Ariston describes the victim, Katie's, life as being an 'extinguished possibility'. Whether we agree or not,[1] the show also suggests that life's promises and possibilities did not line up for the perpetrator, Jamie.

The patriarchal system is like that. It all seems mapped out, mass-produced like boys' wallpaper. It is notable that in Episode 4 we see sister Lisa's bedroom, decorated in pastel-colours. In 2025, despite it all, all the gender 'reveals' and transgender reals, the logic of boys on one side, girls on the other prevails. These ways of delineating our ways of being in the world still hold muster.

But systems and the lines which connect them sometimes collapse. This struggle between the system in place – already made before one is born – of signification, of patriarchy, and the bits that don't fit is at the heart of *Adolescence*. It is typical of the crime genre – genre, of course, being a system of meaning (cf. Berlant 2018; Seltzer 1998, 2007). This typicality makes it quick and fast to decipher or recognize when we turn on Netflix. We feel like, mostly, we can tell the goodies from the baddies in the programme. The settings are standard (the police station, the interview room) and we have a focus on evidence and recording of facts.[2] Criminalized bodies are screened by the PACE declaration ('the right to remain silent … '), CCTV footage and fingerprints. The latter – the fingerprint – provides an early indication of contradiction of patriarchal systems. In Episode 1, a policeman has to tell Jamie: '*that*'s your ring finger'. The teenager apparently does not know which part of his body to lead with and where he is supposedly destined (marriage) as a 'normal' working-class man.

Nonetheless – and I move off Rachel's vocabulary here – Jamie is superficially at least 'recognized' as the killer from the beginning of *Adolescence*. We apparently have a clear line between him – as the criminal – and Bascombe and Frank as the police. But I venture that there is something more than recognition at play here. It's the bits and pieces: the bodies which do not line up or are misrecognized which unsettle us as viewers but also unsettle the 'normal' boy who enacts such violence. Everything was 'all right' and done 'good' in raising this adolescent boy's body up. The school, and the Secure Training Institute have all the right self-esteem building murals: YOU ARE A RAINBOW OF POSSIBILITY!; BELIEVE DREAMS!.

But there's the bit that escapes these universes: these state educational and training systems. Even the standard incel script doesn't quite work: Jamie is 'bright' and knows his Brunel, he is not just some dupe who slavishly follows Andrew Tate.

What comes into play here is the fact of a body – a sexed body – which in patriarchy is marked by a promise. That promise is of women for men in a system of domination. This promise grips boys like Jamie, despite well-meaning teachers, clued-in Dads (Bascombe, not Eddie), and spaces where women can be the boss (the psychologist, the detective). The circulation of women as an object for men remains. They work to *still* the sexual agitation and frustration of men. The boy who snapped and shared Katie's sext is aptly nicknamed 'Fidget'. Aside from Fidget, we also see Mum and Lisa calming Eddie through the repetition of his position as 'Dad'. Not only do they *still* men's drive, but these women are also reduced to a 'top half', function as 'tits' (and other bits), in their circulation – marking them out in the patriarchal system as 'slags'. Weakened by this mark, the promise patriarchy offers is that the body of such a woman (a 'slag' woman) is there for the taking. It is a fantasy (such promises always are) but it *works* within the system. In this moment. In this space. However, for Jamie, it does not work. His overtures to Katie, after she is marked out as a slag are refused. His 'clever' ploy to seduce Katie fails.

And a universe explodes. He stabs her to death.

But then, in the final episode, there's some re-aligning elsewhere: a drawing for Dad's birthday, an art class at the Secure Institute – a stitching together of some future, albeit marked by a tear. Jamie says on speaker-phone '*I'm changing my plea*' to guilty.

This might, perhaps, suggest that there is some promise of a different way within the patriarchal structure, one which accounts for the shame and guilt when the promise of patriarchy explodes, albeit at the cost of a woman's life.

Adolescence and working-class masculinity

Brett Nicholls

I draw upon Antonio Negri's take on neoliberalism, particularly his book *The End of Sovereignty* (Negri 2022). Negri charts the shift in sovereignty from the state to capital, and with it the reconfiguring of the working class around norms derived from Thatcherite entrepreneurialism. I see *Adolescence* as a family psychodrama/crime story situated in this late Thatcherite context.

Adolescence is a story about the British working class. The main characters, the Miller family, Eddie and Manda, and daughter Lisa, find themselves caught up in a horror. Lisa's brother, Eddie and Manda's son, Jamie, is a monster. The show raises the question (though doesn't provide any answers) of how is it possible for a monster to emerge within this seemingly respectable late Thatcherite family.

As I stated, I will focus on the question of class and, in particular, the representation of masculinity within this class. I begin with the origin of the respectable working-class family. This is a residue of the post-World War II Fordist era, in which there is a class compromise as the working class is incorporated into the capitalist, Keynesian Welfare state. In this era, conflict between capital and labour is contained, among other things, by a link to patriarchy. Working-class men have no wealth and social power, but they are made little kings over their own household with their own woman. Their self-worth and social value come from being the provider for their family and, crucially, from what Eve Sedgwick (1985) calls the homosocial bonds of the workplace, unions, sport, the pub and working men's clubs. In other words, rightly or wrongly self-worth comes from being a provider *and* from solidarity with other men.

In this Fordist context, even though Keynesian welfare is a strategy by the state to protect capital from the conflict between capital and labour, the compromise opened the state to contestation. Working class struggle flowed from the aforementioned membership and solidarity. The state responded to this struggle with violence to squash strikes and other forms of social action. But the struggles intensified in the 1960s and 1970s. And Capital haphazardly responds with neoliberalism in the 1980s in the hope of maintaining the hegemony of Capital (Davidson 2023). This strategy is entrenched today.

In *Adolescence*, we encounter a working-class family – and a character Eddy, living his life in part in the form of Fordist era masculinity of the post-war period. Eddy is the everyman. Not exceptional, not wealthy or politically powerful, or in the 'frontline troops of patriarchy' (Connell 79). He is the complicit little guy sharing in the 'patriarchal dividend' (Connell 79) with his own little kingdom, making his way as provider for

comfortable, respectable British family life. He worries he is spending too much time at work, but providing is important. And, crucially, he is proud that he isn't violent like his father, who seems to be a leftover form of the pre-war disciplinarian (King 2015, 68). Eddy is a man who exercises self-restraint.

However, there are important differences from the aforementioned post-war consensus. Unlike the limited but politically effective homosociality of post-war working-class men, for Eddy there is no solidarity at all. This absence is one of the most striking aspects of the show. Eddy is a manual worker but doesn't have any mates: no union, no pub (so much a part of British working-class life). There is no sense of a leftist sensibility, which might include solidarity with like-minded workers. Rather, his identity is thoroughly neoliberal. He is the owner and operator of a small business and, when considered in relation to his lack of solidarity with others, stands out as the lone individual that is central to neoliberal ideology (Connell 2005, 254; see also Wilson 2017).

His son, Jamie, is born into this neoliberal situation but the masculine value of individual dependability and restraint embodied in his father becomes, seemingly inexplicably, contrary and violent. Jamie murdered his classmate, Katie. Alongside this violent act and the life of Katie herself, which remains problematically on the show's margins (Horeck 2025), this monstrousness is no more dramatically realized than in Episode 3, in which Jamie responds to forensic psychologist, Briony, with insults and misogyny. That Eddy is circumstantially positioned to grapple with the horrific consequences of this viciousness alone is dramatized in a compelling final scene. In utter despair, Eddy collapses alone in Jamie's room. The camera lingers upon the figure of his brokenness, his body curled up in a foetal position is reduced to helplessness. The figure of the self-reliant and dependable late Thatcherite masculine subject is upended.

The gravitas of this scene is not without a cause. The show suggests the power of social media, particularly upon the school aged in the context of the school environment, exceeds the directions of teachers and, crucially, families, even the respectable Miller's. The show suggests Jamie's violence stems from reactionary and misogynistic social media influencers, such as Andrew Tate, who undercuts the hegemonic neoliberal masculinity Eddy lives. Responses to the show have tended to highlight the dangers of such influencers upon seemingly vulnerable young men (Cantrell and Hopkins 2025; Murphy, Roddy, and Skelton 2025; Purdy 2025) or called for governments to implement protectionist measures (Lawson 2025).

However, concerns about the vulnerability of youth and the persuasive power of social media merely repeat public anxieties about the corrupting effect of broadcast television. What such concerns overlook is the broader social and economic context of media use itself and, in the case of the show, how it is represented. As I have stated, the show represents family life, particularly the father and son relationship, in the context of late Thatcherism. What we find, in my view, is the neoliberal emptiness of the promises of capital for both father and son. For the father Eddy, the brittleness and loneliness of being a little king with no solidarity. For the son Jamie, both the emptiness of his father and the reactionary social

media that peddles more of the same, that the only way to have worth as a man is to dominate women and be wealthy. If we are to discuss masculinity today, which the show has precipitated, the key question is how to find a form of masculine self-worth without misogyny and in solidarity with others.

Three takes on the one shot in Adolescence

Catherine Fowler

When I read in early reviews of *Adolescence* that each of the four episodes was filmed in one shot, I must admit that I was expecting the television equivalent of a Michael Haneke or Chantal Akerman film: stillness, contemplation and a demand for us to pay attention (see De Luca and Nuno Barradas 2016; Rhodes 2010). The rapid congealing of public opinion upon the series around the consensus that 'something must be done' about young men being negatively influenced by online content and interactions (Horeck 2025, 2–3) only redoubled my expectation that long takes could be behind these reactions. My assumptions were shaped by the tendency of art cinema scholars to connect slow style with virtuous spectatorship, for example, Karl Schoonover identifies: 'a more active and politically present viewing practice' (Schoonover 2012, 66) while for Asbjørn Grønstad, lack of interruption: 'provides a condition of possibility for intrinsically ethical acts, such as recognition, reflection, imagination and empathy' (Grønstad 2015, 274). Many of the responses to *Adolescence* would fit with those outlined by Schoonover and Grønstad, as produced by an arty, slow, contemplative attentiveness. It was therefore a great surprise when, in the first few seconds of Episode 1, after framing DI Bascombe (Ashley Walters) in a medium close-up, the camera moved around him and then kept moving, endlessly. In this response, I want to explore the paradoxes of the perambulating one shot for creating a 'culture of concern' (Fowler and Moro 2025). In this short response, I will limit my discussion to three potent characteristics that can be identified in *Adolescence*: continuousness, choreography and contiguity.

Continuousness

The one shot must keep going. The on-goingness of the one shot is what separates it from 'declarative' long takes (O'Sullivan 2017, 245) which involve set piece perambulations of several minutes that stand out from otherwise conventionally edited scenes in film and television. Such continuousness is used in Episode 3's interview with the psychologist to create tension: prohibiting pause. Since there is no editing to position us with one or the other character, we are instead made subject to the unbalanced shifting flow of Jamie's mood, without a break. The resulting episode is claustrophobic and exhausting. The ceaselessness of this particular one take necessitates a drama shaped by small peaks, rather than a more measured three act or building, climactic structure. For the NZ classification office there was force behind this mode of unfolding, so much so that they issued a caution that despite Netflix's 13 rating 'the realistic style and heavy themes make [Adolescence] an intense watch' (Te Mana Whakaatu 2025a; see also Te Mana Whakaatu 2025b).

Choreography

In *Adolescence*, the one shot must also keep moving, operating through a kind of peripatetics that violates the conventions of the crime genre: denying us the motivation, the crime and the resolution. Despite the assertion above that *Adolescence feels* real, the perceptual realism that André Bazin (2009) so treasured in the static long take is dispelled in *Adolescence*'s one shot by the constant camera movement. Thus, I would argue that the 'real' that we feel derives from a somatechnics created by choreography – or the movement of the camera around bodies. Episode 1 in the Police Station establishes conventions that are then repeated across the series. First, there is the follow shot, where we track behind or in front of a character. Second, there is the 'hand off', as the camera leaves one person to follow another. In both cases, the dynamics of the environment, typically a corridor, creates bodies that are suspended 'between'. O'Sullivan argues for something similar when referring to the repetitious camera movement through corridors in *The West Wing* or around operating theatres in *ER* (2017, 242). In publicity for *Adolescence* writer Jack Thorne observes that the series is not a '*who*' done it, it is a '*why*' done it (Still Watching Netflix 2025). Yet, the restlessness and contingency of the choreography defies the kind of questing search for knowledge that we associate with detective, suspense and crime genres, to replace it with a drifting immersion in the immediacy of now, with no end apparent.

Contiguity

The one shot keeps us close, overpowering our desire to pause and reflect. In Episodes 2 and 4, the ongoingness and peripatetics of the one shot almost feel obscene in the face of the grief and suffering in evidence in the school and home. Spatially immersive and temporally intense, we find ourselves adrift in the proximate. Perhaps, we question the fruitlessness of DI Bascombe and DS Frank's (Faye Marsay) search of the school, or struggle with the family's lengthy drive to the DIY store. Frustration could arise out of such experiences. For sure, the lack of editing deprives us of the means of identification through which we can align ourselves with some bodies over others. We also miss the meaning-making of 'pointing' that would be provided by changes of camera angle and shot size. Therefore, the ever-moving camera denies us of any distance or positioning apart from the action that would allow for the kinds of ponderous states of mind detailed by Schoonover and Grønstad.

Creating a culture of concern

In this short response, I have outlined three characteristics of the one shot as used in *Adolescence*. Beyond the already shocking focus upon the aftermath of a violent attack by a teen boy upon a teen girl, I would argue that there is something about how the story is told that can help explain the startling number of calls to action that it has generated. I have suggested that in combination the one shot's continuousness, choreography and contiguity provide a shape for our experience of the series that is relentless, immersive and intense. Crucially though, what we learn from this elementary attempt to pin down the characteristics of the one shot is how it offers a very different positionality and impact to those provided by either classical editing or the long take. There is no attempt dramaturgically to convince us or provide one truth, since rather than the privileged, omniscient positioning of shot counter-shot patterns, over the shoulder shots and close

ups, through which we identify with characters and know whose side we are on, we have the untethered wandering of the one shot. Similarly, a different relation to the visual and the visibilising of violence is marked by the fact that rather than the 'sustained looking' (Pye and Gibbs 2017, 15) of the static long take that rewards us with meaning if we give our attention to it, with the one take we are caught in the flow and unable to stop it or rise above it. Despite the increasing number of dramas 'based on a true story' aiming to raise concern about a cause – think for example of the recent *Mr Bates vs. The Post Office* (Television series), (2024) – it is still relatively rare for fiction to make a difference in the real world. That *Adolescence* has done so without manipulative editing or the 'unmanipulated integrity' (Pye and Gibbs, 8) of long takes suggests that there remain other ways to move us – to connection, emotion or action. Thus, the series offers a call for action to film and media scholars also to study the history and poetics of the one shot.

Adolescence as (dubious) educational tool and policy driver

Michael S. Daubs

The Netflix series *Adolescence* has provoked important debates about teenage boys (and girls), their experiences online, the influence of the so-called manosphere, represented in the show via mentions of Andrew Tate, and misogynistic and potentially dangerous attitudes towards women. It is perhaps no coincidence that the popularity of the show comes, while there are policy discussions about how or if to regulate social media. Australia has been praised for a recently approved ban on the use of social media for children 16 and under (J. Taylor 2025), and similar bans have been proposed or are under consideration in Ireland (Kavanagh 2025), and New Zealand (Ensor 2025), among others (Akkoc 2025). While *Adolescence* may not be a direct factor in those examples, its compelling story and contemporary relevance are some of the reasons why the United Kingdom, for example, will be screening the show in secondary schools throughout the country (Hui 2025). Prime Minister Kier Starmer has suggested the series could act as a 'cautionary educational tool against the toxic "manosphere"' (Macdonald 2025).

These policy proposals reflect a commonly held opinion that is also suggested in *Adolescence*, particularly in episodes three and four: that social media and the content accessible there were a causal factor in Jamie's murder of Katie. That suggestion, and the fact that each episode is comprised of a single shot – a 'oner' in industry parlance – arguably foreclose the exploration of other potential causes of misogynistic violence and harm. To illustrate why. I want to briefly examine the affordances of the oner format for storytelling and addressing the complicated issues of contemporary masculinity, alienation, misogyny, and the role social media play in exacerbating these issues. Ultimately, while the oner results in a compelling narrative, the format is ill-suited for providing a nuanced discussion these complicated issues necessitate.

The prominence of the oner is one of the reasons *Adolescence* initially gained public attention. Promotional material from Netflix repeatedly highlighted that each episode was 'filmed in one unflinching and continuous shot' (Kinane 2025). Reviews of and commentary on the show also regularly mention each episode comprises a single take

(see, for example, Mangan 2025; Sepinwall 2025) and comment on how that format 'immerses us completely in this particular time and place, sustaining the tension so we never get a chance to look away' (Ward 2025).

The oner is also undoubtedly one of the reasons *Adolescence* is compelling. The series tells a captivating and dramatic story based on an amalgam of real-life events (Zhan 2025), is well acted and scripted, and technologically and logistically masterful. The oner results in a mix of what Vianello (1985, 34) calls the 'prestige aesthetic' of live television anthologies in the 1960s, the sophistication and polished aesthetic of what Dunleavy (2018) refers to as modern high-end television dramas, and documentary forms like direct cinema. Crucially, and in contrast to another form of documentary called cinéma verité, direct cinema does not incorporate elements such as voiceover narration and instead adopts a strictly observational mode that affords filmmakers 'unprecedented mobility and intimacy in their desire to peel away all signs of constructedness and manipulation' (Lucia et al. 2016, 15). The goal of direct cinema was not to deeply interrogate an issue or provide answers, but instead to present the world 'as it enfolded before the camera', while 'remaining committed to journalistic objectivity' (Beattie 2004, 84).

The observational, direct cinema mode the oner approach references provides the show with sense of immediacy, i.e. the sense that we as viewers are somehow present in the events that we are watching (White 2006, 351). Immediacy often conveys a sense of veracity or realness (Humm 1998, 231–232), even for fiction. In *Adolescence*, for example, the oner allows the audience to experience more of the administrative and procedural elements of Jamie's arrest and processing, which are sometimes simplified or skipped over in more traditional television crime dramas. The sense of immediacy or presence also affords a strong affective or emotional connection to the events and characters (Kavka 2008, 7; Kornbluh 2023), and identification with, or at least an empathy for, those characters – aided by the performances of the actors.

The oner and the observational mode it employs also limit opportunities to develop some elements of the story or understand character motivations. While there is a sense of immediacy, there is also a sense of passivity and, paradoxically, disconnection. The audience is not privy to the inner thoughts of the characters. There are no monologues or soliloquies to give a glimpse into what Jamie thinks of his father, the women he sees online, or his classmates at school. Aside from video footage in the police station, there are no flashbacks to provide context, or the ability to see events in two different places at the same time. Finally, the observational focus on the police, Jamie, and his family means the audience misses out on the experiences of the girls at the school or even Katie, the character whose murder is the catalyst for the events of the show. Perhaps that mix of immediacy and unknowing, for lack of a better term, is why the show attracted so much attention. At the same time, that mix also constrains how nuanced the exploration of the issues raised by the show can be.

In short, while co-creator Jack Thorne (quoted in Kaur 2025) suggests the show is a 'whydunnit' instead of a 'whodunnit', the exploration of 'why' is underdeveloped. While Andrew Tate and others in the 'manosphere' do promote and glorify abuse of and violence against women, a development which should not be minimized or ignored, proposals to ban social media arguably do not address the 'right' policy problem. Rather than thinking of 'manosphere' content as a cause, it might be more productive to think

about susceptibility to those messages as a symptom of other social factors, such as alienation, economic precarity, loss of community or preconceived biases. These are issues addressed in other sections of this contribution.

Adolescent identities, algorithms and ambiguity

Rachel Anna Billington

The story *Adolescence* tells is about more than social media, online misogyny and its spilling-over into real lives; it is also about relationships, identity, autonomy and power. It presents a glimpse into the ways that contemporary algorithmic technologies augment our epistemic environments and distort recognition relations (à la Hegel, Honneth, and Taylor) and offers a pathway into a broader discussion about the social, political and interpersonal impacts of social media technologies. Meanwhile, the story that *Adolescence* does *not* tell is one of hope and resilience, dialogue and recognition, and the ways in which many young people experience social media as sites for self-discovery, self-esteem and for meaningfully connecting with others. Resisting the impulse to moral panic which has become characteristic of *Adolescence*'s public reception (see Gower 2025; Prange de Oliveira 2025; Youngs 2025), the conversation ought instead to consider what it is *about* Jamie's experiences that made him vulnerable to the algorithmic overtures of manosphere figures. By the same token, we ought to consider how it is that the majority of young people come through their online adolescences relatively unscathed – what is the difference here?

While the details of Jamie's pathway to violence are not made explicit in the show, what we can deduce from the story is that he has become affiliated with misogynistic online spaces which have provoked him to violence against a female classmate. From a recognition-theoretical perspective, we might perceive that Jamie has come to *recognise himself* in the identity articulations and worldviews made available in these online spaces. Such articulations traffic in perceived aggrievement and victimhood while fostering a sense of rejection and alienation which, paradoxically, become the foundation of a shared sense of identity. To share in these same feelings has the effect of bonding group members in solidarity, conferring a sense of validation, affirmation and self-esteem associated with being a rejected self. Through affiliation with this collective, then, Jamie comes to recognize himself *as* a self that is rejected, alienated, and unloveable – a self who is driven to extreme violence from within this algorithmically curated subject position. We glimpse moments, throughout the show, in which this subject position is further reified: for instance, when Jamie is branded an 'incel' by the girl that would become his victim and the cyber-bullying which followed; the psychologist's refusal to engage his questions about whether or not she thought him ugly; his father's own emotional unavailability – all instances which exacerbate his sense of alienation and confirm his outcast worldview.

In my own research with 494 teenaged New Zealanders (Billington , 2026) I was fortunate to conduct an in-depth interview with a 16-year-old male – 'Jacob' – who expressed an affinity with manosphere figureheads, including Andrew Tate. This interview confirmed to a large degree the role that recognition plays in the online identity explorations of young people. Jacob perceived these online spaces as 'self-improvement

communities' through which, he attested, he developed a greater sense of self-confidence, overcame a problematic relationship with pornography, and became less concerned with trying to impress and gain acceptance from people in his offline life. However, as he drew more aligned with the worldviews of the manosphere, he was less able to share his perspectives with people in his offline life, who rejected these worldviews as problematic and offensive. In this sense, Jacob's developing worldviews were having the effect of further alienating him from his peers and family members, impacting his capacities to connect with others. Here, we land on an important point – social media *alone* is not responsible for radicalization; rather, online and offline worlds are a hybrid ecosystem, and as young people negotiate their developing identities, they swim simultaneously through both digital and non-digital spaces which are inextricably entangled and mutually informing.

Identities are dialogically constructed – that is, they are discursively negotiated in communion with significant recognition partners (C. Taylor 1994, 34). For Jacob, finding resonant identity articulations within the manosphere but being unable to share or work through these articulations with those around him, his opportunities for dialogical, discursive processing were inhibited, and he came to adopt the associated worldviews relatively uncritically. However, during our interview, Jacob relished the opportunity to share what he was learning and work *through* his developing belief system. In doing so – in hearing his own words spoken aloud – there were moments of dissonance which he was quick to identify, and which prompted reflection, adaptation and often a softening. Where his views were rigidly held prior to the interview, throughout our discussion Jacob wrestled with his perspectives, arriving at a more nuanced, middle-ground position. Dialogue and recognition thus become important interventions for mitigating harmful belief-adoption – and our best defence against algorithmically induced radicalization.

Considering that algorithmic social media platforms 'structure the possible field of action' (Foucault 1982, 790), they can thus be considered 'technologies of power' (Lemke 2015, 4), which govern behaviours, subject users and co-constitute human identities. When epistemic and interpretive resources are distorted or limited to the degree that extremist and prejudicial beliefs are inculcated and capacities for recognition are undermined, and insofar as these resources are algorithmically directed into the feeds of unwitting social media users, a question emerges about whether boys like Jacob and Jamie Miller can be considered *culpable* for their beliefs. Discussing the ways that social media users are 'cluster[ed]' according to their demographics within 'red-pilled' epistemic environments associated with reactionary right-wing and extremist worldviews, Warren Sack and Wendy Hui Kyong Chun reflect that such interpellation is 'not active but passive'; that such 'identification is imposed, rather than chosen with one's choice or agency' (Boler and Davis 2021, 139). Insofar as adolescents are interpellated into the subject positions made salient by the algorithm, and insofar as these subject positions are not chosen, it follows that their own capacities for autonomy, self-knowledge and recognition can be undermined by these machines.

However, and for the most part, young people are not experiencing social media as necessarily harmful. Rather, many of my young participants – Jacob included – expressed acute awareness of the ways in which algorithmic technologies can override user agency and promote potentially harmful outcomes. As such, a large proportion of young people are pushing back against these dynamics and developing their own strategies for mitigating the

harms of social media – including ditching their smartphones, deleting apps, and making efforts to be more mindful and intentional about their social media use. Coming to perceive these technologies as agential machines bound by their own logics and with little care for the well-being of users, adolescents are demonstrating a level of wisdom which enables them to resist reification; to avoid becoming 'subordinated to power' in this way (Butler 1997, 2).

Conclusion: five perspectives on Adolescence

It is tempting to conclude our discussion with a definitive statement. But this would surely be reductionist. As we state at the outset, there is no single take that might neatly contain all the show's ambiguities and nuances. However, with an awareness of such a temptation and with the view to promote further discussion, we conclude by noting some overlaps and tensions across our takes.

Two questions play out. The first is what compelled Jamie to commit this heinous crime? The Miller family turmoil hinges around this question and, as we suggested, there is no straight-forward answer. Is it the detachment of father and son (Eddy spent too much time at work)? A vengeful response to the failure of patriarchal promises? Bullying at school? Or the power of social media algorithms to go to work on self-recognition? Perhaps, it is all these and more. At any rate, all our takes are committed to the representation of the social location for the drama. The Millers are a working class, heteronormative family with all the hegemonic signifiers of normality. This situation is ruptured in such a way that the family institution is rendered helpless.

The second question is what makes the show compelling enough to warrant the widespread public attention. No doubt, in the current context of panics around social media and the vulnerability of youth the loose linking of reactionary influencers to Jamie's violence is irresistible. As we discuss, the vulnerability of youth is not uniform across contexts. Youth can be and often are resilient. Nevertheless, given that the Miller family are powerless against its force, it seemingly follows that calls for more government intervention upon social media are surely warranted. What is crucial to note here, and this is a key feature of the crime genre, is precisely what the crime threatens. Although in this case, we would need to consider what the cause of the violent crime threatens. As we have suggested, here *Adolescence* is unremarkable and conservative. The heteronormative nuclear family is under threat.

Apposite this threat, the one-take technique ('oner') at the stylistic level has been publicly applauded. The oner produces a reality effect and an immediacy and intensity that captivates the audience. However, despite this demand for attention, the problem with the oner is that it fails to bring nuance to, and this is surely how *Adolescence* has been positioned in the public imagination and social issues. Since perspective is limited, rather than cut between-subject positions, the result is ambiguous. Where we might ultimately stand on what the show says about the manosphere and violence, is less textually produced than our own dispositions opposed from without.

Notes

1. For a more detailed discussion, on whether *Adolescence* repeats the marginalization of women victims of sexual violence in its focus on Jamie see Michael's contribution to this

article. See also *NY Mag*'s *Vulture* where the author asks 'What about Katie?' (Keating 2025), noting DS Frank's aside in Episode 2 that 'the [male] perp always get the front line'. The author suggests that this line has an inoculating effect as a 'meta' moment which off-sets at the pass such feminist critiques of the series. The tendency to efface the woman victim in favour of focusing on the usually male perpetrator is discussed by Jeanis and Powers (2016).

2. Seltzer (1998, 2007) argues in his work on 'realist' and true crime media that the focus on *mediation* – of recordings; writing down; capturing via interview is *more* important than the archetypal characters of good cops/bad criminals. More disturbing, he suggests that crime media is a pathological 'media doubling' of a broader 'wound culture' (1998) of mediation, surveillance and (self) observation, premised on a subjectivity which is always already 'visibilised and exposed' (2007, 25). Further, Seltzer argues that the assumption of crime media seeps into the world apparently 'off screen' where the criminal, the deviant and the abnormal necessitates a constant 'taking stock' and mediation (3).

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